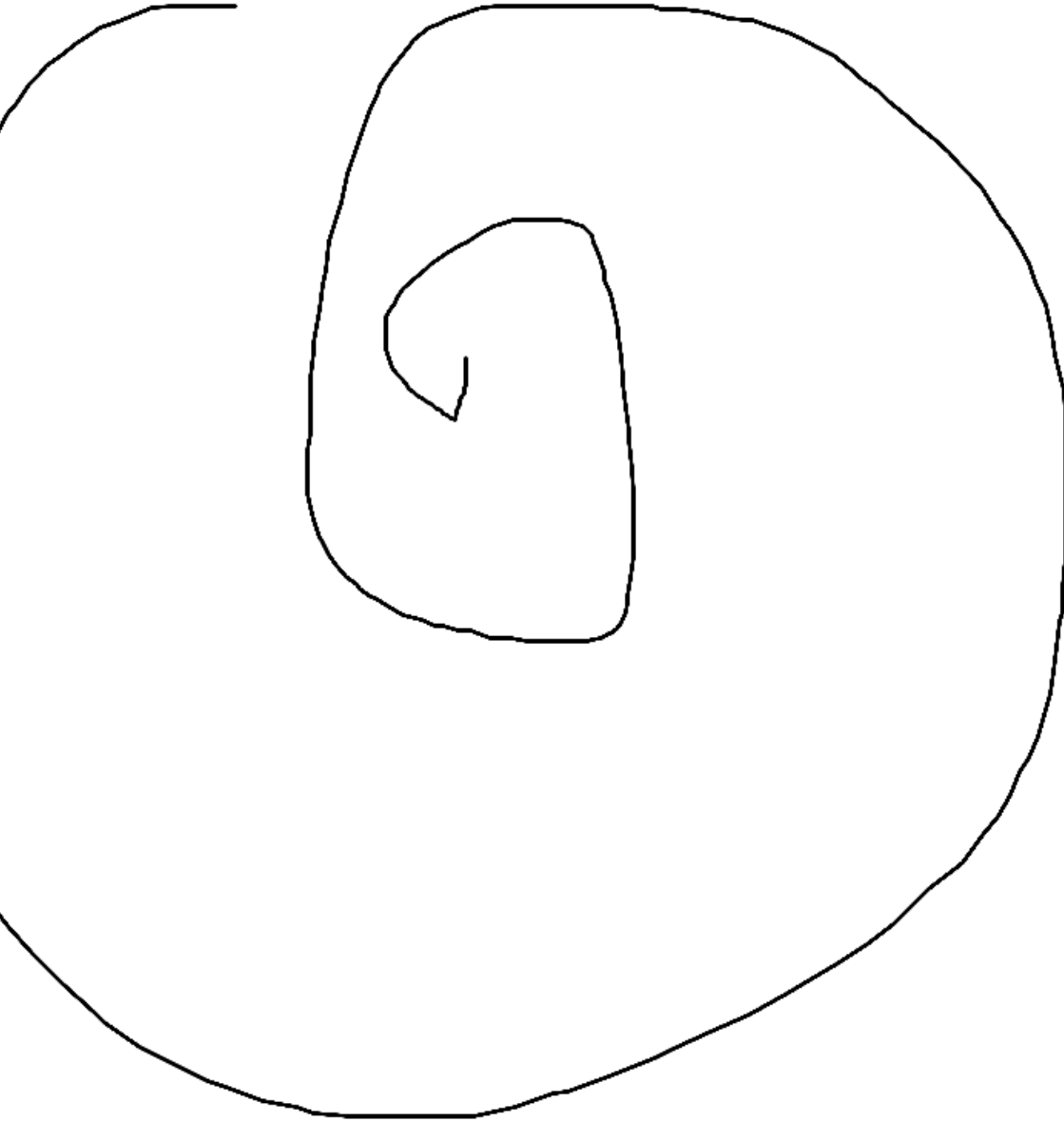

The Spy School in Flower City

Tofutush

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1

It was a Sunday afternoon. I was curled up on the sofa with a book when there came a knock on the door. Dad went to get it.

A man in a jet-black uniform stood in the doorway, sporting two blue horns and a welcoming smile, hands held behind his back. Dad nearly slammed the door right back into his face, but the man reached out a hand and stopped it.

"Wh-What did I do?" Dad's voice was trembling as if he saw a spider in a corner.

"Why, Mr. Entity, if there's anything you did, that was raising a wonderful daughter! Is little Harmony home?"

His eyes locked with mine for a split second. I pretended to not notice, sinking back into my book, though my attention was still focused on him. Black uniform, purple boots, and the shiny silver badge on the hat — the man was from the Ministry of State Security. What did he want with me?

Dad turned around to face me, looking relieved that the officer wasn't coming for him. "Harm? It's for you."

I put down the book and made a face. Shortening "Harmony" to "Harm" was so silly, but I couldn't get Dad to stop calling me that. It eventually stuck.

"Actually," said the man, "is Mrs. Frosting home? I would love to discuss this matter with the whole family."

Dad nodded. "Darling!" he called.

Mom came out from her study. "What is it?" And then she saw the man in the doorway. "Oh. What's the matter, officer?"

They sat down around the tea table. I put her book face-down on the sofa and scooted over. The man introduced himself as Sky Elmwood Dazzle. Mom made tea.

"I am here on behalf of the the Middle School for Young Officers in Training Affiliated to the Ministry of State Security." Sky began. "I know it's a mouthful. We usually call it Ministry Affiliate.

"Your daughter is about to graduate elementary school. We are giving her an offer to attend middle school here."

"Really?" Mom burst out.

"You are not mistaken. Our administration sees potential in a student like Harmony."

For the second time, he looked into my eyes. I averted my gaze, feeling my heart beat quicken. Was he serious?

I felt compelled to say something lest Sky thought I was an idiot. "Uh, what's Ministry Affiliate?" I asked.

"It's a special school ran by the Ministry of State Security," Sky said. "Where you can start early in your training to become an officer there. We will teach you things you'd never learn anywhere else." Sky took another sip of tea. "You get to participate in missions, catching spies that are damaging our national security.

And finally you can graduate into becoming an officer just like me."

Oh. I had heard about the mystical school before, of its prestige and its secrecy. *Everyone* wanted to attend Ministry Affiliate.

Not me though.

"I was supposed to go to Flower City Middle School with my friend," I said.

"Sugarcane? I just visited her yesterday. She agreed to attend."

I caught my parents eyeing each other.

"...I can see why," Mom said finally. "Sugarcane is a bright kid."

I coughed.

"Of course, you're amazing too! That's why uncle Sky came to you too!" Mom added immediately with no genuineness in her voice.

"I'm going wherever Sugarcane is going," I said.

"Do we have time to consider?" Dad asked.

"Of course," Sky produced a booklet from his pocket. It was an introduction of the school. "When you're ready to attend, come to our office" — he pointed to an address written on the back cover — "with your ID, elementary school diploma, and a document photo receipt. Make sure to take a new photo. The deadline is August 1st. Please don't tell anyone else about it until then."

"Thank you, officer," Mom said.

"I should be thanking *you*." Sky got up and headed for the door. "Bye! I look forward to teaching you." The cup of tea was emptied.

"Well," I said, "let's go get the photo taken!"

"Let's not rush things," Mom said. "Take some time to consider it."

“What is there to consider?” I picked the book back up from the sofa and headed for my room. “Sugarcane is going.”

“Do you know what that school is?” Mom chased walked after me. “They all call it Spy School.”

“I think I’ve heard of it,” I set the book facedown on my desk.

“It’s known for its rigorous coursework. A lot of people end up quitting. I remember a year when the graduating class had only half the kids they started with.”

Now I was reasonably worried. “Where do these kids go then?”

“Back to normal middle and high schools. Although, because what Spy School teaches are a lot different, a lot of them have trouble catching up.”

“Really?”

“So,” Mom continued, “all I’m saying is to take more consideration before making a significant choice like this.”

I thought about my future as a middle school dropout. But I also thought about going to school without Sugarcane. Without her warm and uplifting laughter, her gentle lecturing about class content I didn’t understand, and her confident authority in everything that brought me doubt. She had been my best and only friend all throughout elementary school. I didn’t want to leave her.

“I’ll go find Sugarcane at the playground.”

Sugarcane was already there when I arrived at the playground. She was sitting on a bench, legs crossed, too cool for any of the swings or slides; she wasn’t on her usual bench, but another one, next to some shrubs. I yelled at her, and she turned to face me.

“Hey!” she yelled back, swiping her bangs out of her eyes.

"Hey," I replied. "I want to ask you something. There's this guy who came to my home earlier today. He wanted me to attend this Ministry school and he said you agreed to go. Is that true?"

Sugarcane smiled. "Yes."

"So you're going?" I asked.

"Of course!" Sugarcane said. "It's a nice school. It's way better than Flower City Middle School. Honestly, I'd say anyone who goes there is a loser. So glad we're not among them."

"This is great!" I was hopping up and down. She was coming with me!

"*What* is great?" Came a teasing voice from behind. I turned around. It was Rose, leaned against a lamp post behind the shrubs.

Rose was a classmate of ours. Sugarcane didn't like her, and she refused to hang out with any of Rose's friends either. Except that Rose was friends with nearly everyone else. Sugarcane would've been alone all the time if it weren't for me, although I suspected that she would've been fine with that. *I* would not allow that to happen. Sugarcane, all alone. What a horrible image in my head. I shoved the thought away.

"Oh, hey Rose," Sugarcane said without turning her head. "What's 'great' is that you're here, and you can play with things appropriate for your age." She waved at the swings and slides, around which a couple of kindergarteners were happily chasing each other.

Rose decided to ignore the comment. "What is this 'ministry school' I heard from you two?" She said with a face full of smug. "Some fancy version of a juvie?"

"Sitting in the grass getting your ass all wet and a bunch of bug bites, just to ask that basic question." Sugarcane shook her head. "This is why they didn't recruit you." She stood up, still facing away from Rose. "C'mon, Harmony, let's go. Talk some-

where without little spies snooping on us. Not that she's a good spy, but still."

I got up to follow Sugarcane, but I needed to defend her too. "You're just jealous *you* didn't get invited," I said as we left.

"Still latching yourself onto her butt, I see," Rose shouted behind us.

"Don't mind her," Sugarcane said. "You're right, she's just jealous she couldn't be like us."

When they were far enough away from Rose, Sugarcane finally turned excitedly to me, her face blooming into a wholehearted smile unlike the cool condescending smile she put on in front of Rose. "You're really coming! I said I'd only attend if you do!"

"Hey, I also said that!"

"Looks like they *did* go find you!"

"I'm so glad we'd still be together," I said. "I wouldn't know what to do without you."

"Me neither. We can go sign up as soon as we graduate."

The day of graduation finally came. We had received our diplomas, went to take pictures right after the ceremony, and returned to my home, where we begged Dad to walk us over.

"Can't you wait until your mom gets home?" Dad rubbed his temples.

"But that would be way into the evening!" I said. "Would they even still be open?"

"Aren't you eager," Dad sighed.

"Thank you, uncle Entity!" Sugarcane said sweetly.

The school was a twenty-minute walk away from my home — fifteen minutes from Sugarcane's. "That's close enough for you to go to school yourselves," Dad said.

"I can make a detour to Sugarcane's and we can walk the rest of the way together," I said. "It's only a couple minutes longer."

"That sounds great!" Sugarcane said. Dad was falling behind them.

We reached the address. It was a large campus, surrounded by barbed wires mounted on gray walls. Tall, foreboding buildings loomed down at us, with barred windows and paint peeling off. I must've passed this building many times in my thirteen years of living in Flower City, but it had never occurred to me that this place was a school. A juvie, more like. Oh no, was Rose correct?

A security guard stood at the intersection, guarding the road leading to the gate. "State your business," he ordered.

I turned around to look at Dad, but he was lingering way behind. "I'll wait for you girls here!" He called out.

"We're here to sign up for Ministry Affiliate," Sugarcane answered the guard.

"IDs."

Sugarcane already had hers ready while I fumbled for my own. The guard tapped each card against a machine in his hands.

"Who's that guy?" He gestured towards Dad.

"My dad," I answered.

"Alright," the guard stepped away, beckoning us forward.

We reached the school's gate. The only indicator that it was a school was a small metal plaque, silver on the gray wall, bearing its absurdly long name. A gatekeeper sat in the security office by the door.

"New students?" He said. "You're very early. It's not even July yet. May I see your IDs, please?"

Again, Sugarcane already had hers ready. I had decided to put hers back in the folder during the walk.

After checking our IDs, the gatekeeper pressed some controls. Next to the big sliding gate, a small human gate swung open. "Right there," he said. "You'll see it."

We entered to find a clearing of dusty concrete tiles between us and the main buildings. A single bauhinia tree, evident by its signature heart-shaped leaves, sat in a tree pit near the corner. Under its shade was a single canopy tent labeled *New Student Registration*. In the shade of the tent, behind a laptop on the table, sat none other than Sky himself.

"Sky!" I yelled out in excitement and ran towards him. Sugarcane followed close behind.

"Hi!" Sky looked up from his laptop. "So good to see you here! Documents, please."

I gave my folder to Sky, realized that my ID was still in my hand, and handed that over as well. Sugarcane, however, had put her ID back into her folder during the run and simply handed over the entire thing.

Sky went to work, checking their IDs against their diplomas and against a list he had on the table. He typed into the laptop, shoved their photo receipts in a bag, returned their documents, and typed some more.

"You're all set!" He smiled. "Orientation day is on September the first. I expect to see you then!"

"Thank you," we said. I gave the imposing building behind the tent one last look.

"This is actually the high school part," Sky explained. "To get to the middle school, you turn right immediately after coming in. There will be people showing you the way by then, so don't worry."

We said our "thank you" again and left. I took one last look at the imposing buildings in the campus. I would spend the next three years here with Sugarcane. Six years, if we also attend high

school here. Ministry Affiliate, the best school in the city, and arguably the whole country.

I was now a part of it, and Sugarcane was by my side.

We passed the guard, greeted Dad, and started for home. I suggested we go to Sugarcane's and then back to my home so we could familiarize ourselves with the route.

At dinner, I excitedly told Mom about my enrollment. She merely nodded, not looking up from her bowl. "Just remember," she said, "sometimes, the teachers and the schools make mistakes too. Nothing they teach you is an absolute fact. Sometimes they're wrong about things, so you need to judge for yourself. We can also help you; just ask us."

"Yeah, yeah," I said, not paying attention.

"I'm being serious. If you're having any questions, or doubts, just tell us and we can answer it."

I merely rolled my eyes. My parents were always acting like they were my friends, and it was really corny. Sugarcane was my only friend.

"Or if you feel too pressured and want to transfer. I have teacher friends who would be happy to tutor you if you need help, so if you transfer out and have trouble catching up..."

"I'm not going to transfer out," I said. "School hasn't even started! Have some faith in me!"

I wondered why Mom was so worried. Did she know someone who attended the school and had to drop out, out of all the children of her colleagues she never stopped talking about? Mom had a never-ending treasure trove of stories about her colleagues' children and which schools they went to, what jobs they got, and what they had for breakfast. Every time I thought she had run out of colleagues to talk about, she brought up someone new.

I looked at my dad, but Entity was being quiet as usual.

“I’m full,” I scraped up the last bit of rice in my bowl and headed for the kitchen. It didn’t matter if Mom kept worrying. I had Sugarcane. I would be fine.

2

September the first happened to be a Monday. I woke up early, even before Mom had left for work, and asked her to send a message to Sugarcane's mom saying that I was leaving. I stuffed a re-heated bun into my mouth, triple-checked my school bag, and set off for Sugarcane's.

"Be safe!" Mom said as I left.

I arrived just in time to see Sugarcane coming out from her apartment building. We greeted each other and continued on our way.

The guard was no longer present at the intersection. Instead, a barrier was set up on the lane, and a row of traffic police hurried around, directing the flood of cars that had taken over.

"Don't loiter!" Some of them yelled. "Drop off and go!"

Some of the students were pulling huge suitcases around. High schoolers, judging by their height and how they radiated maturity. They were kind of scary to look at.

"Don't cross the road here," an officer standing near the intersection put up an arm in front of us. "Turn right on this side and cross in front of the school entrance."

We did as she told. At the entrance, the car gate was completely open as high-schoolers carted their suitcases in. Someone, presumably an upperclassman, was holding up a big sign that said "*New students come here!*" And they did just that.

"Are you seventh graders?" The upperclassman asked.

"Yes," we replied. I twisted my backpack to the front, about to take out my ID card.

"Head right in," the upperclassman said. "Turn right, and you'll see a tent where you can check which class you're in."

A teacher sat behind the table under the tent. We handed over our ID cards and stated our names.

"Harmony... you're in class five. Sugarcane — also class five!"

"Yes!" I jumped up excitedly. "We're in the same class!"

"You'd wager Sky pulled strings?"

Grade seven class five was on the first floor of the main building. It was dimly-lit, with floor tiles that had once been white. Posters on the wall bore portraits of famous ancient people and their quotes, but they were too faded to read. Unusually clean spots on the windows outlined the stickers that had been torn off and the residual rubbed clean. At the front, the teacher's desk sat on an elevated platform, where a huge stack of boxes lay, presumably textbooks, waiting to be handed out. The blackboard hung on the wall, the bottom groove caked in chalk dust. The projector screen was retracted, leaving the default blue screen blasted straight onto the blackboard. Forty or so wiggly, rusted desks cramped into the small space, and some kids were already

sitting in them. Some lifted their heads as we walked in, but their interests faded when they realized we were only fellow students, not the teacher.

Sugarcane found two spots for us right next to the door and we sat down next to each other. A girl with thick, long hair was right behind me.

Sugarcane turned around and said "hi" to her. She lifted her head, and that was when I noticed her eyes were of different colors, one blue and one pink.

Heterochromia, or two souls? Her ears were drooped so I couldn't check the insides of her ear.

And then I saw, on her forehead, she had a *third* eye. Yellow, with a black iris.

"Hi," she said back.

"I'm Sugarcane. This is Harmony. Nice to meet you!"

"Nice to meet you too. I'm Cosmo."

Cosmo. "That's a pretty name," I said.

I felt a weird tingling sensation in my mind as Cosmo looked at me. It felt familiar, though I couldn't remember when I last felt it.

"Thanks. Harmony is a good name too." Her third eye blinked. So it really was an eye.

"What's up with your eyes, if you don't mind?" Sugarcane asked. "I've never seen someone with different colored eyes before."

"Oh," Cosmo flashed a smile. "I have two souls."

"Whoa. How?"

"Apparently I was supposed to be twins. But I ate the other kid or something," Cosmo rolled her eyes, including the third, which she pointed a finger to. "Probably how I got this thing too. I can't actually see out of it. It's just there, being creepy."

"I don't think it's creepy at all!" Sugarcane said.

“Really,” Cosmo crossed her arms.

“Well, maybe a little,” Sugarcane admitted. “But now I know what it is.”

A new student arrived at the door and poked his head in. “Is this class five?” He asked.

“Sure is,” Sugarcane immediately turned towards him. “I’m Sugarcane, this is Harmony, and this…”

“Cosmo.”

“Hi, I’m Sunny.” He walked over to the seat next to Cosmo, behind Sugarcane. “Mind if I sit here?”

“Not at all,” Cosmo said. She scooted over a little bit, the chair making a horrible scraping sound against the floor as Sunny settled down.

We spent the rest of the time chatting. Well, them at least. I didn’t speak a lot; I just watched. They caught Sunny up to Cosmo’s eye situation. I wanted Sugarcane to stop talking to these strangers, but I didn’t know how to do that without being too obvious. So I just watched as Cosmo and Sunny grabbed Sugarcane’s full attention.

The classroom slowly filled up. I glanced around, estimating about thirty or so people in our class.

At eight o’clock sharp, a teacher walked inside and the chatter died down. It was none other than Sky Elmwood Dazzle himself, in his MSS uniform, holding a cup of coffee that said “#1 teacher.”

“Good morning, class five!” He said cheerfully, setting the cup down on the table. Sugarcane finally turned her back to Cosmo and Sunny.

“Sky definitely pulled strings,” I whispered to Sugarcane.

“No I didn’t,” Sky had apparently heard that. “They go off by who went to whose homes. And that means I had met all of you

before. Nice to meet you again. I will be teaching you politics and tradecraft, and I hope we have a great three years together."

Politics? Tradecraft? They were right, Spy School wasn't like other schools!

"Now, I'd like all of you to get in a line outside of the classroom. We're going to the soccer field for the opening ceremony."

Some kids audibly groaned, but a line was quickly assembled. Sky led them to the soccer field and placed them between classes four and six. Luckily enough, the sun was behind them, so we didn't have to stare into it as the principal gave his speech.

I stood right behind Sugarcane. The principal was a middle-aged man. I supposed he was also in the MSS, though he wasn't wearing a uniform, but a suit instead, which means he didn't have a hat on, exposing his bald head for all to see. We couldn't make out a word he was speaking, so we just stared and laughed at his head.

"You see that patch of light on the wall? It moves around." Sugarcane pointed. "His head reflected the light over!"

I snickered.

"Hey," came a voice behind us. I turned in horror to find Sky standing right next to me. "As a man with little hair myself, I didn't appreciate that. You're not gonna be seeing the principal every day like you do me and I'm worried." He tipped his hat up to reveal a mohawk, with the other parts of his head shaved to the scalp. "Once you're done laughing about this, I hope you'll leave me alone for the rest of our acquaintance."

"Sorry, sir," Sugarcane said, and I quickly followed suit.

After they returned to the air-conditioning of the classroom, Sky unpacked the box on the table. It contained a stack of cards.

"Here are your student cards. Come up here and find which one has your name on it. You'll be needing this to swipe into the school from now on, as well as the cafeteria."

Sugarcane went up first and found both of our cards. She also went up when Sky asked for hands in helping him give everyone their textbooks.

I soon amassed a big pile. Language and literature, math, physics, chemistry, biology, geography, and politics. But none titled tradecraft. I spent a good while writing my name and class number down on all of them. Sugarcane settled back in her seat and did the same.

At last, Sky had one final announcement to make.

"Tomorrow you will have an entrance exam," he said.

Voices of "what?" "no!" and "aaaarrrrgggghhhhh..." echoed throughout the room.

"Don't worry! It's just here to see where everyone's starting from. We're not even gonna return it back to you after we grade it. Don't be stressed about it."

"Oh no," I said, perhaps a little too loudly. "They're gonna separate us! These classes are temporary; they're gonna split us into new classes based on the test results!"

"Isn't that illegal for public schools?" Sugarcane replied.

"Exactly!" Sky raised his voice. "That's why that's *not what we're doing*! You're all staying in this class. We just need to know who's a Math Olympiad kid and who can't count to ten on their fingers! Although," he added, "I hope everyone can count to ten here."

"What subjects are gonna be on the test?" Cosmo asked.

"I don't know. I hadn't seen the questions. But they could be anything. There's bound to be questions about things you never heard of before, and that's okay."

"Do you have any preparation materials?" Sunny asked.

"No. It's just an assessment of your current level, not how well you can cram."

"We should cram the new textbooks, got it," Cosmo said.

"That's not — whatever," Sky threw his hands up. "Just make sure to get enough sleep."

On that note we were dismissed. It was only eleven o'clock. We packed up the books — my backpack was visibly heavier — and Sugarcane waved goodbye to Cosmo and Sunny at the gate. I invited Sugarcane to her home for lunch, but she said her mom had already made lunch for her.

"When did she tell you?"

"Oh, she texted me just now."

"How?"

"Wait, I never told you? I have a phone now. For middle school." Sugarcane pulled it out of her pocket. It was modern-looking, perhaps the latest model of StarPhone, and had an adorable phone case featuring kittens and puppies.

"Awww, no fair! My parents didn't even *mention* giving me a phone."

"Then you can bring it up. Tell them it's dangerous for you to walk twenty minutes to and from school every day with no way to contact them."

"You're right," I said.

We waved each other goodbye at Sugarcane's apartment building.

During lunch, I told my parents about orientation day and the entrance exam tomorrow as I munched on steamed buns.

"Wow, they get stricter every year," Mom said. "They didn't use to do entrance exams for seventh graders."

"Lucky us," I said.

"There is still time to quit," Mom said.

"I'm not *going* to quit," I was getting tired at Mom's lack of faith. "Not unless you can get Sugarcane to quit with me."

Mom sighed, but Dad was being surprisingly cheerful. "I have a present for you!"

He pulled a box out of the trench coat he wore all year long. It was a mobile phone, same model as Sugarcane's. "Since you're in middle school and all grown up," he smiled.

"Really?" I stared at it, wide-eyed. "Wow."

"The word you're looking for is 'thanks.'"

"Um-hm," I nodded.

Dad put the phone box on the shelf behind him. "Lunch first."

"You're spoiling her so much," Mom shook her head.

I spent the afternoon setting up her phone at Sugarcane's. We created accounts and added each other on StarChat, and spent about an hour finding the perfect pair of matching wallpapers. We settled for two halves of a picture that could be completed if we put our phones together.

On Sugarcane's desk, the new textbooks were strewn about, all of them open on unit one. Had she been studying before I got here?

I suddenly remembered to ask. "When I was talking to Cosmo, I felt this weird thing in my head. I remember feeling it before. Have you?"

"Oh, that. She's a mind-reader."

"That's it!" I remembered. The feeling came from your mind being read.

"Most mind-readers won't let you feel that, though," Sugarcane said. "Maybe she just hasn't been trained."

I wondered what thoughts of mine Cosmo heard. There was a mind-reader on our class in elementary school too, but like everyone else, she didn't hang out with us. I didn't really like the idea of someone listening to her thoughts. I should stay away

from Cosmo. *Sugarcane* should stay away from Cosmo. Why did she still talk to her, if she knew about Cosmo's powers?

Late into the afternoon, my phone buzzed. My own phone! It felt surreal. It was Mom. "I have to go home now," I said. "See you tomorrow!"

We hugged each other goodbye like we always did, and I was on my way home. I spent some time researching (on my phone) how to block mind readers by myself, but most of the methods were too complicated. The simplest one seemed to be playing a popular and catchy song in your head so they could get stuck in the mind-reader's head too, making it harder for them to focus on your mind.

Tomorrow would be the *actual* first day of school. I would do my best, exam or no exam.

3

The digital alarm I set on my new phone rang at seven o'clock sharp, but I had been awake long before.

I ate another one of their buns — just about how many did Mom make? — but she insisted on packing another in my bag. "You'll get hungry after taking the exam."

Silly. I had taken plenty of exams in elementary school and I never got *hungry* from sitting at a desk doing multiple choice questions. But I wasn't in the mood to argue with Mom. She put a bun into a plastic bag and stuffed it in my bag, among my new textbooks.

I started for Sugarcane's, skipping along the way, which soon proved to be a bad idea as I was heaving when I met Sugarcane.

"Are you worried about the exam?" Sugarcane asked.

"Maybe a little," I admitted. "Sky said we would still be in the same class, but what if he doesn't allow us to sit together?"

"I'll fight him," Sugarcane said. "But well, realistically, we could both pretend to have really bad eyes so he would put us in the front and center."

Front and center had always been Sugarcane's favorite seat in any classroom. I didn't quite like the teacher's attention it brought me, but I wanted to be next to Sugarcane.

Sky was standing in front of the door when we arrived at the classroom. He was no longer wearing his MSS uniform, but instead a wrinkly checkered shirt, which I have concluded after years of observation was the official uniform for teachers who appeared nice and lenient but graded harshly. All the other students were along the wall, setting down their backpacks and taking out their pencil cases.

"Please put your backpacks and electronics outside the classroom!" Sky was holding a metal detector. "You may only bring your pencil cases and student cards."

"Can I take my tissues?" Sunny was snuffling.

"Let me take a look."

We put our backpacks next to each other and unzipped them to take out our pencil cases. There was a line assembled near the door, waiting to pass through Sky's metal detector. He wasn't even checking too hard; just a nominal wave and you were in.

"Find the desk with your number on it," Sky said.

It seemed like the arrangement was in alphabetical order. I sat in the first row, right in front of the teacher's desk, where the "#1 teacher" cup sat steaming. Soon everyone was seated, and Sky came in with four thick brown folders, all of which were marked as "confidential."

I glanced around. Cosmo was a couple seats away from me, with a helmet fitted over her head. A mind-reading blocker. She looked miserable in it, but with a tired sort of misery, like she was also used to this. Another student seemed to have a hyperaware-

ness-blocking cloak on too, but being in the first row, my sight was limited.

"I'm going to hand out the answer sheets," Sky said, and explained how they worked. "The most important part is to color your student number in, at the top here." He held up an empty answer sheet and gestured to the space at the top.

When I received mine, I wrote my name and colored in my number at the appropriate spots, double-checking to make sure I got it right.

"Next, I will hand out the questions sheet. Do not write on either sheet until the bell has rung. You will have two hours for the first section, and you may leave one hour in. Then there will be a ten-minute break. The next section lasts for one hour, and you may leave as soon as it has started."

Three hours?! And we're allowed to leave early? What kind of an exam *is* this?

The stack of questions landed on my desk. I took one and passed the rest behind me. It was a really long, continuous strip, four pages wide, so front and back made eight. The text was tiny, suffocatingly crammed onto the page.

I scanned the questions. The first section was math. And then science. Reading comprehension — I had never seen a passage this long!

"The exam begins eight thirty sharp. Please wait for the bell to ring."

And on that note, a loud, screeching sound came blasting out of the speakers.

"You may begin."

Equations. What's the value of x? The first question was easy enough. Question two. *Uh, what does this little "2" above the* x *mean?* I skipped that one. *What is "log"?* Skipped again. *What is this weird crowbar? Oh my...* The bun in my stomach was acting up.

I ended up skipping the entire math section and moved onto science.

I knew the answer to the first few questions from random books and TV shows. But soon I also became stuck. I couldn't even understand the questions, let alone answer them.

I glanced around again. The kid beside me was still on page two, and that made me feel a little better. But then I realized I had skipped over the first three pages and the dread returned.

Name the components of an atom. Paired with a funny picture with blank labels. More skips. On my answer sheet, there was a huge blank box — *is that space for an essay?* I checked out the corresponding question. It was programming. A chunk of example code was given, but I could understand none of it.

After that came two interesting ones. I had to crack an encoded message. The first one was a set of numbers. Maybe I should replace them with letters? If A is 1 and B is 2... Slowly, a coherent message emerged. Wow, this is great!

The next code was a jumble of letters. I tried replacing A with Z and B with Y, but it didn't work. What about A with B and B with C? That didn't work either. I gave up.

I skipped to reading comprehension, but by the time I reached the end of the passage, I had forgotten the beginning. I looked at the clock. Thirty minutes in. This is *nothing* like what I had seen before. How am I going to survive this?

The second passage was in ancient language. We had studied ancient language in sixth grade, but those passages were at most two to three lines long. This one had three entire paragraphs, and I couldn't understand a thing.

I looked at Sky. He was holding his own copy of the questions sheet, mouth curved into a relaxed smile, occasionally jotting down some calculations and sipping from his cup.

The exam continued in silence, save for the shuffling of paper and creaking of the chairs. The clock ticked.

Sky cleared his throat, grabbing the attention of those closest to him, like me. "You have one hour left. You may leave now if you want, but please remain quiet."

One kid really got up to leave. Sky walked over to his desk and collected his answer sheet.

Did he seriously complete that? In *one* hour?

I simply sat at my table, turning the papers over and over, as if a new question that I could answer would suddenly pop out of the page. I contemplated leaving. It's not like I'm doing anything else, is it? But Sugarcane hadn't left. I stole glances at Sugarcane out of the corner of my eye, and she was calmly focused on the exam like she always did.

Finally, the bell rung again.

"Pens down, everyone," Sky bellowed. my answer sheet was mostly left blank. "Students at the back, please pass your answer sheets to the front."

I received a messy stack of papers. The topmost one was filled with answers. Every multiple choice question had been colored in. Did this kid really know all of the answers?

"Harmony," Sky said. "Stop looking."

I quickly added my own sheet onto the pile and handed it to Sky.

"You will now have your break," Sky said. "You are free to use the restroom, but do not talk to each other. Please return in ten minutes."

We met at our backpacks. I shot Sugarcane an exasperated expression. Sugarcane simply shook her head.

Mom was right, I *did* feel hungry. I ate the bun, which had been flattened into pie between her books, and threw the plastic bag away.

The ten minutes were up, and Sky called everyone back into the classroom.

"You are now doing the second part of the exam. You have one hour, but you can leave whenever. The cafeteria opens at eleven thirty, so feel free to head down and ask upperclassmen for directions. Remember to come back for class in the afternoon!" The new answer sheet and questions were passed down.

I stared at the paper.

"For all the questions below, 'the exam' refers to the first part of the exam that you have just finished taking.

"How many pages did the exam's question sheet have?"

It was eight. I remembered.

"Repeat the second question on the third page. Include the options as well."

I had skipped that page.

"How many paragraphs did the second reading passage have?"

The first one, with the ancient language, had three. I hadn't counted the second.

What kind of an exam is this? An exam about an exam?

The screeching bell came again.

About half an hour in, I gave up. Sugarcane had left already, so I did as well. I packed up her backpack and found Sugarcane on a bench.

"What *was* that?" She said.

"I had no idea."

"The second part was awfully meta. The first part was okay."

"The first part was okay?"

"Well, it didn't go as bad as I thought. I did a few questions in each section, though the coding one was weird. Why would they let us write code by hand?"

"You did the coding one? You knew what to write?"

"Well, I learned a bit about programming over the summer."

"When did you *do* that?"

"Over the summer?"

"I never knew."

"It was just a hobby thing, really. And I guessed on most of the other multiple choice questions."

"Wait, what?"

"I guessed. I just picked a random option that felt like it."

"You could *do* that?"

Now Sugarcane was quite shocked. "Well, what did you do then? Just left them blank?"

"Well, yeah! I didn't know you could just fill in a random answer!"

"Hey, it's nearly half past eleven. Let's go find the cafeteria."

The cafeteria wasn't hard to find, as it was the only place on campus where all the students were heading. Dim lights shone on the rows and rows of tables below, full of people and their chatter. The floor was sticky with decades of spilled sauces, and I worried about the sanitary conditions in the kitchen. We grabbed a plate each and fell in line.

A voice came from behind them. "Why was the exam like *that*?" followed by some snuffling. It was Sunny. "That was so weird. An exam about an exam!"

"Are you okay?" I tilted my head at him. "You sound sick."

"I'm fine. Just turned the AC on too low yesterday," he insisted, but immediately sneezed into his hands. "Eh, maybe not that fine. I was going to ask to sit with you two, but..."

"You can sit with us," Sugarcane offered.

"Are we sure about that?" I asked.

"It's not like it's a flu. He just caught some chills, it's not contagious."

"Fine," I wasn't about to disagree with Sugarcane, but I did sit diagonally from Sunny.

I opened my mouth to talk to Sugarcane, but Cosmo suddenly popped up. She pointed to the seat right in front of me, next to Sunny. "Mind if I sit here?"

"Of course not," Sunny said.

"Nope!" Sugarcane said at the same time. I nodded in agreement, though I didn't really like the way Sugarcane smiled at her. It was distinct from her "I'm better than you" smile she showed to Rose all the time, her "I *have* to smile on this occasion" smile in class photos, and her "I'm so mature and obedient and could do no wrong" smile that she put on in front of adults. It nearly resembled that friendly smile she had shown me and me only.

"I'm so tired," Cosmo said. "I don't think I wanna do another exam ever again, if they're all like that."

"Yeah, it's like an exam about an exam," Sunny repeated. "I don't even see the point." he concluded his point with a loud sneeze.

"Bless you," Cosmo said. "You wanna see my cat? Her name is Fluffy." She pulled out her phone and showed us a picture of a gray cat with long fur.

"That's so cute!" Sugarcane's eyes lit up. Cosmo swiped to a video of Fluffy grooming herself.

"The video is thirty minutes long," Sunny said with playful concern.

"Heavens forbid a cat keeps herself clean," Cosmo shot back.

"I'm more concerned about you just recording her for half an hour straight," Sunny said.

I had always wanted my own cat, but Mom was allergic and Dad got freaked out by anything that moved. I loved going to the pet store at the mall with Sugarcane and just staring at the kittens in their boxes.

“Harmony, right?” Cosmo’s voice made my head snap up. “You don’t seem to talk a lot. How are you doing?”

I was at a loss of what to say. “Um. Pretty fine.”

As soon as I opened my mouth, I felt the tingling sensation in my head again. I started blasting the most popular and catchy song I could think of, while also trying hard to come up with something else to say. “Uh, how does your mind reading work?”

“I’m glad you asked!” That was surprising. I was expecting her to be more upset about it. “The thing is, I technically *do* have mind-reading, but I can only tell whether people are lying or not,” she explained in a practiced way that suggested she said the same thing over and over to different people all the time. “So I can’t read your thoughts the same way usual mind-readers could. Another interesting thing is that it seems to work in the background, and I don’t have to be intentionally focused to tell.”

That was reassuring, I guess. I just have to be mindful not to lie in front of her.

“That’s really cool still!” Sunny said. “I’ve met a few mind-readers, but none of them made me feel that weird feeling.”

“Oh, that.” Cosmo shook her head. “I couldn’t really sign up for any training because my level is too low. But I had literally never been wrong *once*. They still only gave me a super low level because I fail most of the tests. It’s so annoying. So I hadn’t learned *anything* about mind-reading, or how to prevent you from feeling that thing.” She banged her chopsticks against her plate in frustration. “Sorry.”

“Don’t be sorry, you’re born with this! And I don’t mind the feeling,” Sunny said.

“Oh, thank you. I was apologizing because my grandma gets mad at me if my chopsticks makes noises against the plate.”

Sugarcane cleared her throat. "Two truths and a lie. So I have forty-six plushies on my bed; the food here is way worse than my family's; and I like you two a lot."

It was the third. Sugarcane had always loved her family's cooking. I do too; whenever Dad was in the kitchen, he kept hurting himself in ways I couldn't have imagined, and all Mom wanted to make was steamed buns. Sugarcane's parents made delicious food, and her grandparents' cooking was even better. As for the plushies, there were exactly forty-six, lined up neatly along where her bed touched the wall. Carrots, Slushy, Taffy, Spotty, Joy, Truffle...

"*You* know, of course," Sugarcane said, cutting off my thoughts. "And I bet Harmony does too. Sunny, which one do you think it is?"

I took a couple seconds to realize she had been addressing Cosmo at the start.

Sunny scratched his head. "Uh... the plushie one?"

Cosmo smiled. "All three are true."

Wait, what? Sugarcane... liked them a lot?

What was I thinking. Sugarcane was always friendly and sweet. Of course she would say that. She liked everyone. She just liked me more.

When we were all finished with our food, we put our plates away and headed back to class. Sugarcane consulted the schedule and concluded that the first class in the afternoon was tradecraft.

The desks were still placed in exam order, but some students were arranging them back into order. We joined them, and after we finished, sat down where we sat on orientation day.

Students slowly filled the room. Sky walked in just as the class bell rang, and our first class in Spy School was about to begin.

4

"Welcome to your first class of middle school," Sky said. "Tradecraft. This will undoubtedly be the most important class in this school, given our nature, but I don't want you slacking in any other classes either." He scanned his gaze sternly across the room.

"Allow me to make a proper introduction. My name is Sky Elmwood Dazzle, reserve officer of the Ministry of State Security. I am the head teacher of class five, and I will be teaching both you and class four tradecraft and politics."

I noticed another box near the foot of the teacher's desk. Were those our textbooks? Why didn't he give it to us yesterday?

"So, to begin," Sky said. "Espionage is a major way we fight the Cold War. Spies travel around the continent, infiltrating organizations and gathering intelligence. We, the Ministry of State

Security, is the hand behind the veil controlling them. So will you, in the future.

"In addition, we also need to protect our *own* information from getting stolen. That's called *counter*-intelligence. Intelligence and counter-intelligence are what we do the most, and the focus of this class."

He then pulled up a slideshow and blabbered a bit about the history of the MSS, about its predecessor the intelligence unit of the Republican revolutionary army, and its finalization through a series of leaders and restructures into the Ministry we all know and love today. I wasn't sure on either knowing or loving, but I guess that was what I was here to learn.

"I hope the entrance exam this morning is still fresh on your minds," Sky said.

Across the classroom, students started groaning.

"That is an introduction of something you will need to learn: to quickly memorize information you will not see for a second time."

"Is *every* test going to be like that from now on?" Sunny asked.

"Oh, no," Sky replied. "That was only for the entrance exam. I came up with that idea, actually. Every year I'm reminded of my own genius." I rolled my eyes as he genuinely sounded obsessed with this idea. "But from now on you will have exams specifically about memorization."

We spent the rest of class memorizing number sequences that got longer and longer.

Towards the end of class, Sky finally pointed to the box beside the desk. "Will someone hand them out for me, please? Each student's name should be written on the inside."

After a while of confusion and name-shouting, everyone had their copy of the book. Its cover was plain gray, made with a weird texture that felt dusty when I touched it, though I knew from the

smell that the book was brand new. My full legal name was not only printed on the inside cover, but also watermarked across every page.

"This is your tradecraft textbook," Sky said. "Read out the word on the first page."

"Classified," the student read.

"Right. Let me lay out the most important rule here at Ministry Affiliate. Never leak the textbook."

I nodded absent-mindedly, skimming the first couple pages of the contents. It was a brief history of espionage, which seemed like easily-obtainable information.

"This text is the foundation of which Ministry Affiliate was built. Leaking it would essentially be broadcasting the curriculum to any random person — even our enemies. It is punishable by prison time. And of course, you will also be expelled."

Now he caught my attention. I stroked the cover, in awe of the importance such a plain-looking book carried.

"If I see you treating this book like just a normal book you can leave scattering around, I *will* be having a serious talk with you."

He didn't need to say any more. I was already clutching the book close to my chest.

"For homework today, read the section on espionage history. Class dismissed."

And on that note, the bell rung.

"That was melodramatic," Cosmo said immediately.

"Better safe than sorry," Sugarcane said. "Because I don't think they're joking about prison."

Sunny was holding the book like a bar of gold.

"Come on," Cosmo gave him a nudge. "P.E. is next. Let's get there on time."

I stashed my textbook into my desk drawer and followed them out onto the soccer field. The sun was blazing overhead,

so I looked downwards to avoid the light. A single person was standing in the only shade provided by a banyan tree growing in an L-shape in the corner. She beckoned us over to the empty spot in front of her, next to the racetrack, but still made of the same synthetic red floor.

"It's so hot," I said to Sugarcane.

"No shit," she said. "The autumn tiger makes everything hell."

We merged ourselves into the blob that was forming in front of the teacher. She was short, about the same height as me. And only then did I realize how... odd, she looked. She was a bicorn, but one of her horns was broken, and she seemed to hang her head a bit lopsidedly as a result of unbalanced weight. She had an eyepatch over one eye, and wore a thick trench coat in the heat. Oh no, I thought Dad was the only person who insisted on wearing that awful trench coat no matter what. Was there a secret society of them?

I saw Sugarcane frowning. "What's wrong?" I asked.

"That must've hurt," she said. "It broke fairly close to the base, where there are way more nerves."

"Oh, my." I reached up and touched my ears, thinking how much it would've hurt if someone pulled them off my head. When I was a kid, I would scratch my ears all the time until all the fur fell off and the skin showed. I dropped the habit when I became close friends in Sugarcane in third grade.

I looked at Sugarcane's tall, thin horns, suddenly growing worried if she would be in danger and I wasn't there to save her. Worse, I *was* there but I failed. I started to feel dizzy as my heartbeat quickened.

I shook my head. I had had this thought way too many times a day. Sugarcane could take care of herself. She'd be fine. I took deep breaths and forced myself to calm down.

The preparation bell rung.

"Hear this music?" The teacher asked as the bell ended. "That's the preparation bell, but in my class it's the bell for class. So," she addressed the students joining the group as she talked, "in the future, come in class later than this bell, and you will be considered late."

Sugarcane leaned in and whispered, "what an ass."

I snickered. Sugarcane should be the last person to worry about this; she was always ready ahead of time.

"This is P.E. class. Call me 'teacher' or 'coach' or whatever. You'll be learning Wood-style martial arts." She pulled out a clipboard and a pen. "Class president, take attendance."

No one moved.

"What? Where's the class president?"

"There... is no class president," a few students said, their scattered voices forming a sentence with inferable meaning. "It's like the first day of school."

The teacher shook her head. "Who's your head teacher?"

"Mr. Sky," was the reply.

"That stupid fucking moronic son of a mutt," the P.E. teacher muttered under her breath. Some student giggled, evidently offput by an adult swearing. They should meet my dad when he thought I wasn't listening.

"You," the teacher said, handing the clipboard and pen to the student closest to her, a tall boy with yellow horns not unlike her own. "You're taking attendance for this class from now on."

The boy looked like he regret standing this close to the teacher.

"When... what's your name?" The teacher asked.

"Thunder," he replied.

"When Thunder calls your name, come stand here in a row." She scanned over us, counting under her breath. "Make three rows, each with ten people. Hurry."

Thunder looked at the clipboard and said, "Bloom?"

"Here," a girl walked up to where the teacher pointed.

Thunder scribbled something onto the clipboard and opened his mouth to say the next name, but his voice was drowned out by the class bell. We waited awkwardly, Bloom especially so, and the teacher tapped her feet impatiently until the music ended.

"Go on," she said.

"Cosmo," Thunder said. Cosmo walked to stand beside Bloom.

"Dimple."

I recognized her as the kid beside me during the exam. Hang on...

"Harmony."

I went to stand beside Dimple. The list was still in alphabetical order again. Which meant Sugarcane was again going to be far behind me.

The exam was different; I was used to being separated from Sugarcane during exams. And if I were to sit near her, I couldn't have resisted the urge to peek at her papers, so it was for the better. But for P.E. classes, we had always stood together. But now, she was probably going to be in the third row. What was the point of going to the same school if we kept being separated?

"Juice."

A boy came next to me. Dimple and Juice, my alphabet neighbors. I'd be seeing them a lot later, unless I could help it.

Thunder continued calling on people. It took a while. Finally, he called on "Sugarcane." She stood in the third row, immediately before "Sunny." I looked behind my shoulder as Sunny winked at Sugarcane and she smiled back.

I should be happy that Sugarcane was happy. But why do I feel jealous, then?

It was the smile, I concluded. I had never seen Sugarcane smile at other people like that, except at me. And now, she was using it on Cosmo *and* Sunny.

"And I'm the last one," Thunder said, clicking the pen shut and handing it back to the teacher along with the clipboard.

"Convenient," she said as Thunder joined in behind Sunny. "You" — she pointed at Bloom — "start running. Five laps. The rest follow in line."

Thank you so much for reading this book all the way to the end! Or maybe you skipped here to see what it looks like. Thank you either way!

Read more about Harmony, Sugarcane, and the world they live in on my website!